How Beijing Thinks About AGI and What It Wants From a U.S.-China AI Deal

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Sources: PRC documents, company statements, conversations with experts, and published analysis; public statements may not reflect private views.

Key Takeaways

- **OpenAI, Anthropic, and Chinese AI companies such as Moonshot AI and DeepSeek say they are building artificial general intelligence (AGI), and some of their leaders treat it as a history-ending prize.** But for now, Beijing and Washington both treat AI as a general-purpose technology, like electricity or the internet.
  - The White House has adopted some AI company vocabulary but not their beliefs: a September 2026 executive order renames AI "Super Intelligence" but keeps AI's existing definition.
- Chinese AI companies rarely say publicly that whoever reaches AGI first could win permanently, but their engineers sometimes do.
  - One DeepSeek engineer wrote a widely shared WeChat post: "Anthropic controlling the most advanced artificial intelligence or AGI... would be no less than letting Hitler get the atomic bomb before the Allies."
- Chinese AI companies are split on how to reach AGI: Moonshot, MiniMax and Z.Ai make a similar bet on scaling as OpenAI and Anthropic, while Alibaba, Baidu, and DeepSeek think AGI requires a fundamental breakthrough.
- **Beijing's view can shift rapidly.** The OpenAI/HuggingFace incident and a wave of AI-lab resignations went viral in China as well as the U.S.
- PRC officials often read export controls or calls to slow down as coordinated containment. **Beijing will likely reject any deal they feel locks China in second place.**
  - Beijing would likely accept incident hotlines, joint loss-of-control research, and limits on non-state actors. Their main ask might be export control relief.
- Chinese AI companies are roughly seven months behind OpenAI and Anthropic, putting China's most capable AI companies in line with Meta.

Two Views of AI: Decisive Advantage or Normal Technology

- Leaders at OpenAI and Anthropic have argued that the first to reach AGI could gain a decisive strategic advantage: a lead so large that rivals can never catch up. The other camp, including NVIDIA CEO Jensen Huang, sees AI as a "**normal technology**" and believes that AI pays off through a wide adoption where followers can catch up.
  - **Decisive advantage view:** Sam Altman to Elon Musk (2015): "If it's going to happen anyway, it seems like it would be good for someone other than Google to do it first... [should we] start a Manhattan Project for AI?"
  - **Normal technology view**: NVIDIA CEO Jensen Huang (2025): "whoever applies the technology first and most wins that industrial revolution."
- **OpenAI and Anthropic openly hold the first view. Beijing holds the second, for now. Chinese AI companies sit in between;** several say they are building AGI, but the term is loosely defined and may be marketing in some cases.
- Many frontier AI researchers believe that future AI systems could recursively self-improve: an AI good enough at AI development that it can design the next, more powerful version of itself, and so on. **RSI is why some expect an AI lead to compound, driving a race, and also why they fear AI systems escaping human control.**
  - Dario Amodei: every decision "feels like it is balanced on the edge of a knife... if we don't build fast enough the authoritarian countries could win, but if we build too fast then [existential risk] could prevail."

Beijing Currently Views AI as a Normal Technology, Not a Rupture in Human History

- Matching or beating the U.S. in AI is a top PRC priority, for national pride, growth, diplomatic leverage, military

power and surveillance. Beijing also wants to be seen as the more responsible AI power: state media pointed to the OpenAI/HuggingFace incident as an example of American AI companies "out of control," saying "HuggingFace sought help from a Chinese open source model."
  - Beijing promotes open-weight AI abroad, framing it as a public good and positioning China as the default for the Global South.
- To Beijing, the winner is the country that deploys AI best, not the one that builds it first, so for now it is content to be a fast follower.
  - PRC AI policy, as set out in the State Council's AI+ plan, focuses on adoption, applications, and speed. Chinese AI companies undercut one another until a victor emerges. The victor will likely receive heavy state backing (the same pattern that produced China's solar and EV champions).
- Some official CCP papers are claiming that the U.S. government and American AI companies are conspiring to hold China back, and calls to slow development are often interpreted as a hostile signal that the U.S. seeks to hamstring China.
- Scenarios such as AI 2027 imagine Beijing deciding a lead in AI is decisive, moving to put the state behind one national effort. When Beijing decides a technology is strategic, it can move enormous capital quickly, as with solar and semiconductors. Signs of an all-out-race belief, per Kyle Chan:
  - Importing as many NVIDIA chips as possible
  - Taking over private companies' data centers
  - Closing its free-to-download models, a reversal of its open-source diplomacy

Chinese AI Companies Take AGI Seriously, but Not as a Winner-Take-All Race

- Moonshot's founder Yang Zhilin named his company for a "moonshot" to reach AGI.
- Alibaba CEO Eddie Wu: "AI will certainly not stop at AGI; it will move toward artificial superintelligence … capable of iterative self-improvement."
- Many Chinese AI researchers expect China to catch up quickly even if the U.S. reaches AGI first.
- Leading Chinese researchers warn that AI could escape human control. For example, Peking University Professor Huang Tiejun and Zhou Bowen, Chief Scientist at Shanghai AI Laboratory, have both raised the alarm. Both speak mainly to Chinese-only audiences, which suggests they are sincerely concerned.
- Concern about catastrophic AI risk took hold earlier in the West, and China has far less private philanthropy overall: philanthropists spend $250–600 million a year on frontier AI risk research in the West, against about $20 million in China.

AGI Strategies Follow Comparative Advantages

- The U.S. leads in compute, and its companies often bet on scaling. Meanwhile, China is short on chips but has abundant power; they bet more on efficiency and algorithmic breakthroughs. China trains more AI researchers, but many of the best leave for American AI companies; new exit restrictions may make leaving China for U.S. AI companies harder.
  - DeepSeek CEO Liang Wenfang: "The talent gap is fundamentally a compute gap."
  - According to SemiAnalysis, building a data center, excluding chips, costs roughly one-fifth as much in China as in the U.S., thanks to cheaper labor, abundant power, and faster permitting.
- OpenAI and Anthropic together control 40% of the world's computational power relevant to training new AI models, and will own 56% by 2027 YE at current rate.
- In a structured interview study I conducted, roughly half of 25 researchers at OpenAI, Anthropic, xAi, Google DeepMind and Meta believed AGI or RSI could be reached through a **scaling path**, with more computational power and incremental improvements. Skeptics thought a technical breakthrough was necessary for AGI to materialize, such as a new architecture, equipping AI systems with memory, or a conceptual breakthrough around creativity.
  - OpenAI, Anthropic, xAI, Moonshot, Z.Ai, and MiniMax have the most similar technical bets on scale. Com-

panies like Meta and other Chinese AI players are more skeptical.

What Beijing Would Want From a U.S.-China AI Deal

- Beijing may accept mutual limits, but not a deal that freezes it in second place. Its main ask would likely be export-control relief, the main U.S. source of leverage. Xi has outlined a red line around "seeking unilateral absolute advantage."
- PRC would likely agree to AI incident notification hotlines, joint loss-of-control research, and keeping advanced AI systems from non-state actors.
- Amodei pairs racing to the frontier with export controls to "keep democracies' AI lead over autocracies as large as possible" As Carnegie's Matt Sheehan puts it, China heard only the containment half of the AI safety concerns.
- PRC officials and Chinese AI companies consider the export-control regime hostile.
  - The Minister of State Security attacks "entity lists" and "technology controls." TC260 calls export controls "unilateral coercive measures."